

Open Source License Cheat Sheet

A quick reference. Not legal advice — for authoritative text, read the license itself and choosealicense.com.

The one-minute version

- **No license = all rights reserved.** If you don't add a LICENSE file, others legally *can't* use, copy, or modify your code — even if it's public on GitHub. To be open source, you must choose a license.
- **Permissive** (MIT, Apache-2.0, BSD): "do almost anything — just keep my copyright notice." Maximizes adoption.
- **Copyleft** (GPL, AGPL, LGPL, MPL): "use and modify freely, but if you distribute changes, keep them open under the same license." Keeps the ecosystem open.
- **Pick for your goal:** widest possible use (including companies)? → permissive. Improvements must stay open? → copyleft.

Comparison

LICENSE	TYPE	USE / MODIFY / DISTRIBUTE	DERIVATIVES MUST STAY OPEN?	EXPLICIT PATENT GRANT?	NOTICE REQUIRED?	GOOD FOR
MIT	Permissive	Yes	No	No	Yes	Max adoption, simplicity — a common default
Apache-2.0	Permissive	Yes	No	Yes	Yes (+ state changes)	Permissive <i>with</i> patent protection; enterprise-friendly
BSD-3-Clause	Permissive	Yes	No	No	Yes	Like MIT, but forbids using your name to endorse
MPL-2.0	Weak copyleft	Yes	Only the <i>modified files</i>	Yes	Yes	Middle ground; mixes with proprietary code
LGPL-3.0	Weak copyleft	Yes	The <i>library</i> , if modified	Yes	Yes	Libraries usable by closed-source apps
GPL-3.0	Strong copyleft	Yes	Yes (whole work)	Yes	Yes	Keep the whole project + derivatives open
AGPL-3.0	Strong copyleft (network)	Yes	Yes, even when hosted	Yes	Yes	Servers/SaaS you want kept open even when run remotely
Unlicense / CC0	Public domain	Yes	No	No	No	"Do whatever," no attribution needed

How to choose (fast)

1. **Want companies to use it freely?** → Permissive. Pick **Apache-2.0** if you want explicit patent protection, else **MIT**.
2. **Want improvements shared back?** → **GPL-3.0** (or **AGPL-3.0** if it runs as a network service).
3. **A library that even closed apps should use?** → **LGPL-3.0** or **MPL-2.0**.
4. **Don't care at all?** → **MIT** (friendliest default) or public domain (**CC0**).

Gotchas

- **Add the LICENSE file at the start** — re-licensing later is hard once others contribute.
- **Your dependencies' licenses matter.** A GPL dependency can pull GPL obligations into your project (license *compatibility*).
- **Patent grant (the "patent grant?" column).** Code can be covered by patents *and* copyright. MIT/BSD grant copyright but are silent on patents — in theory a contributor could sue users over a patent on code they contributed. **Apache-2.0, GPL-3.0, and AGPL-3.0** add an *explicit patent grant* (each contributor licenses the patents needed to use their contribution; Apache also revokes your rights if you sue the project over a patent). It rarely bites small projects, but it's why companies favor Apache-2.0 — "permissive, with patent protection." (*General background, not legal advice.*)
- **You can't un-open released code** — people keep the version you gave them.
- **Open source isn't obligation-free for you** — you still owe maintenance, security fixes, and community time.

Reference: choosealicense.com · [tldrlegal](https://tldrlegal.com) · [OSI-approved licenses](https://opensource.org/licenses).